study of this variation is known as biogeography. One branch (phytogeography) examines the distribution of plants, whereas the other (zoogeography) analyzes the distribution of animals. British naturalist and biologist Alfred Russel Wallace is widely regarded as the “father of biogeography.”

In the 18th century, as explorers and colonizers made a record of the plants and animals they saw, a picture of geographic change began emerging. On the great 1831–36 expedition of HMS *Beagle*, Charles Darwin saw species of birds on the Falkland Islands (Islas Malvinas) that did not live on mainland South America, giant tortoises that were unique to the Galápagos Islands, and marsupials such as Australia’s kangaroos. New pieces of the biogeographic jigsaw were falling into place.

From 1848, Wallace conducted years of fieldwork in South America and Southeast Asia. He researched the feeding and breeding behavior and migratory habits of thousands of species, paying specific attention to animal distribution compared with the presence or absence of geographical barriers, such as seas between islands. He concluded that the number of organisms living in a community depends on the food available in that specific habitat.